IN MEMORY OF A TEACHER. IN SERVICE OF CHILDREN.

GAIL ORCUTT

A teacher. A legacy.
A promise to the children.

A memorial tribute honoring the Iowa educator and radon-safety advocate whose work helped inspire the Gail Orcutt School Radon Safety Act.

She fought to make an invisible danger visible.

TA14 Authority Governance Institution LLC
Public educational memorial | October 2026

The classroom may be silent.
The evidence must never be.

She spent her life teaching.

Gail Orcutt taught in Iowa for 33 years. Teaching was not simply her profession; it was a way of helping others understand the world and prepare for the future.

In 2010, Gail, who had never smoked, was diagnosed with lung cancer. As she learned about radon and its risks, she began sharing what she discovered with families, educators, public-health professionals, and policymakers.

She became a founding member of the Iowa Radon Coalition and the Iowa Cancer Consortium Radon Workgroup. In 2013 she received the Iowa Cancer Champion Award for her advocacy.

Gail died in May 2020. Her work continued to influence the effort to protect children from radon exposure in schools.

Her advocacy was not only about a measurement. It was about people who could not see, smell, or recognize the hazard around them.

Radon is a naturally occurring radioactive gas. Long-term exposure increases lung-cancer risk. Testing is necessary because radon cannot be detected by human senses.

A law that carries her name.

In 2022, Iowa enacted House File 2412, commonly known as the Gail Orcutt School Radon Safety Act. It established Iowa Code section 280.32 and requirements for radon testing and response in public schools.

By July 1, 2027: Public school districts must test each attendance center at least once under the statutory testing framework.

Every five years: Testing must be repeated at least once during each subsequent five-year period.

When an initial short-term result is at or above 4 pCi/L: The law calls for another short-term test within 60 days.

When statutory criteria are met: A credentialed specialist must be retained to develop a mitigation plan.

Public visibility: Districts must publish radon testing results on their websites. New school construction must incorporate radon-resistant techniques.

The law establishes important obligations. It does not automatically require continuous monitoring in every classroom, nor does a single elevated reading universally mandate evacuation.

Gail did not live to see the 2022 law enacted. Its name keeps her public-health advocacy visible to a new generation.

What does the evidence prove?

A test documents conditions during a measurement period. It does not reveal every earlier day of exposure. A mitigation plan documents intended action. An installation record shows work was performed. Follow-up testing helps determine whether the intervention reduced radon concentrations.

These records are related, but they are not interchangeable.

DETECT — What was measured, where, when, by whom, and by what method?

CONFIRM — What further testing or expert assessment is required?

AUTHORIZE — Who has authority and standing to approve the response?

ACT — What protective work and communication actually occurred?

VERIFY — What evidence demonstrates the outcome, and what remains uncertain?

CONTINUE — What retesting, record preservation, and disclosure follow?

An installed mitigation system is not, by itself, proof of a verified environmental outcome.

What parents deserve to understand.

Parents should be able to find understandable information about school radon testing: the results, dates, affected locations, follow-up tests, mitigation status, and available verification records.

Communication should distinguish an initial elevated reading from a confirmed result, and a completed installation from demonstrated improvement. It should also disclose meaningful uncertainty.

No monitoring system can reconstruct exposure before measurements began or establish a particular child's historical dose with certainty. Nor can a school radon result alone establish the cause of an individual illness.

But uncertainty is a reason to preserve better records, not to pretend the question does not matter.

Children do not control school testing programs, ventilation systems, mitigation decisions, or public records. The institutions responsible for those systems should be able to explain what they knew, what they did, and what the evidence demonstrates.

The responsibility we carry forward.

We honor Gail Orcutt for the years she devoted to teaching and for turning personal hardship into public service.

In her memory, TA14 Authority Governance Institution LLC pledges to work toward a future in which school environmental concerns are not merely measured, but documented, examined, addressed, and followed through to verifiable outcomes.

We pledge to advance trustworthy environmental records, clearer responsibility for protective decisions, and meaningful access to evidence for the families whose children occupy our schools.

We will distinguish what the evidence proves from what it cannot prove. We will not present an unverified intervention as a verified outcome.

Our developing Environmental Integrity Governance approach asks whether proposed action has sufficient Admissible Evidence, Applicable Authority, and Established Standing. It does not replace qualified radon professionals, health agencies, or applicable law.

She helped make testing a requirement. We pledge to help make evidence of protection impossible to overlook.

This is TA14's independent commitment. It is not a statement by Gail, her family, the State of Iowa, or any other organization.

06 | CONTINUE THE WORK

Her legacy deserves action.

Explore TA14's educational Radon Mitigation showroom, which examines why mitigation installation, evidence continuity, authorized decisions, post-mitigation verification, and ongoing accountability must be considered separately.

www.ta14exchange.com/showrooms/radon-mitigation-evidence-continuity

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PRIMARY SOURCES & FURTHER READING

Iowa Legislature — House File 2412 (2022): Iowa legislative bill record

Iowa Health and Human Services — Radon in K–12 Schools: hhs.iowa.gov

Iowa Cancer Consortium — Gail Orcutt tributes and radon advocacy: canceriowa.org

American Cancer Society Cancer Action Network — Gail Orcutt School Radon Safety Act: fightcancer.org

Independent educational memorial. No affiliation with, sponsorship by, or endorsement from the Orcutt family, Iowa Cancer Consortium, or State of Iowa is represented. This publication does not provide medical or legal advice.